

Container Gardening for Seniors - Printable Worksheets, Calendar and Pot-Size Chart

From *Container Gardening for Seniors* by Helen Marchbank (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

Appendix A - The Planting Calendar

For a temperate climate with the last spring frost in mid-April and the first autumn frost in mid-October. Shift the dates for your own area by the rule in Chapter 4, and write your frost dates on Worksheet C1. "Sow indoors" means a windowsill or a cold frame; "sow or plant out" means direct into the pot outside, or planting a bought plug plant.

Crop	Sow indoors	Sow or plant out	Pick	Note
Salad leaves (cut-and-come-again)	-	Mar to Sep, every 2 to 3 weeks	4 to 6 weeks after sowing	Shade in July; fleece in Mar and Oct
Lettuce	Feb to Mar	Mar to Aug	May to Oct	Bolts in heat; sow little and often
Spinach and chard	-	Mar to May; Aug to Sep	May to Nov; chard to spring	Chard overwinters under fleece
Rocket (arugula)	-	Mar to Sep, little and often	3 to 4 weeks	Fleece against flea beetle
Radish	-	Mar to Sep, every 2 weeks	3 to 5 weeks	Pull young; the fastest crop
Spring onions (scallions)	-	Mar to Aug	8 to 10 weeks	Sow thickly; pull as needed
Beetroot	-	Apr to Jul	Jun to Oct	Golf-ball size is best
Basil	Apr, warm windowsill	Late May	Jun to Sep	Indoors again in Oct
Parsley	Feb to Mar	Mar to Jul	May to Dec, and next spring	Slow to come up (3 weeks)

Chives	-	Plant Mar to May	Apr to Oct	Permanent; divide every 3 years
Mint	-	Plant Mar to May, own pot	Apr to Oct	Cut hard in Jul; rust: cut to the ground
Thyme and rosemary	-	Plant Apr to Jun	All year	Permanent; dry, sunny, lean mix
Coriander (cilantro) and dill	-	Apr to Aug, every 3 weeks	4 to 6 weeks	Bolt fast; sow often
Cherry tomatoes	Mid-Mar	Mid to late May	Jul to Oct	Feed weekly from first flowers
Peppers and chillies	Feb to Mar	Late May	Aug to Oct	Hottest corner; chilli pot indoors in Oct
Cucumber	Apr	Late May	Jul to Sep	A frame; pick small
Courgette (zucchini)	Apr	Late May	Jul to Oct	One plant is enough
Dwarf French beans	-	May and again in Jun	Jul to Sep	Frost-tender; pick every 2 days
Peas	-	Mar to Apr; Jul for autumn	Jun to Jul; Sep to Oct	Netting to climb; pea shoots any month indoors
Potatoes, first early	Chit in Feb	Plant Mar; Christmas bag in Jul to Aug	Jun to Jul; Dec	3 tubers to a 40 L bag
Carrots	-	Mar to Jul	Jun to Oct	Table height beats carrot fly

Garlic	-	Plant Oct to Nov	Jun to Jul	Dry after lifting; rust: cut back
Turnips and kohlrabi	-	Apr to Jul	8 to 10 weeks	Pull small and quick
Strawberries	-	Plant Apr, or Sep	Jun to Jul; perpetual kinds to Oct	Net from flowering; runners in Jul
Blueberries	-	Plant Oct to Mar	Jul to Aug	Ericaceous mix; rainwater only
A fruit tree in a pot	-	Plant Oct to Mar	Aug to Oct	Dwarf rootstock; 50 L and up
Marigold, calendula	Mar to Apr	Apr to May	Jun to Oct	Beside the tomatoes
Nasturtium	-	Apr to May	Jun to Oct	Edible flowers; catches blackfly
Sweet peas	Feb to Mar	Apr	Jun to Aug	Cut every day
Cosmos, zinnias	Apr	Late May	Jul to Oct	Cut flowers all summer
Tulips, daffodils, crocus	-	Plant Sep to Nov	Mar to May	Under the strawberries and herbs

Appendix B - The Pot-Size Chart

The minimum is the size below which the crop will struggle; the better size is what to buy if you can. Litres are the useful measure because the bags of mix are sold in litres; the conversion table below turns them into gallons and pot widths.

Crop	Minimum (L)	Better (L)	Plants per pot	Depth of mix
Salad leaves, rocket, radish, spring onions	5 (a trough)	10 or more	Sow thickly	15 cm (6 in)
Lettuce	5 per plant	10	3 to 4 per 30 cm trough	15 cm (6 in)
Spinach	10	20	6	20 cm (8 in)
Chard	10	20	3	20 cm (8 in)
Beetroot, turnips, kohlrabi	10	20	6 to 8	20 cm (8 in)
Basil	3	5 to 10	1 to 3	15 cm (6 in)
Parsley, coriander, dill	5	10	1 to 3 (sow herbs thickly)	20 cm (8 in)
Chives	3	10	1 clump	15 cm (6 in)
Mint	10	20	1, in its own pot	20 cm (8 in)
Thyme	5	10	1	15 cm (6 in)
Rosemary	10	30	1	25 cm (10 in)
Cherry tomato	30	40 to 50, self-watering	1	35 cm (14 in)
Peppers and chillies	10	20	1	25 cm (10 in)
Cucumber	20	30 to 40	1	30 cm (12 in)

				in)
Courgette	40	50 to 60	1	35 cm (14 in)
Dwarf French beans	15	30	6 to 8	20 cm (8 in)
Peas	15	30	15 to 20	20 cm (8 in)
Potatoes	30	40 (a grow bag)	3 tubers	40 cm (16 in), filled in stages
Carrots	10, deep	20	Sow thickly; thin to 3 cm	25 to 30 cm (10 to 12 in)
Garlic	10	20	4 to 6 cloves	20 cm (8 in)
Strawberries	5 per plant	30 for 5 or 6 plants	5 to 6	20 cm (8 in)
Blueberries	30	50	1	35 cm (14 in)
A fruit tree	50	70 to 90	1	45 cm (18 in)
Annual flowers	5	10 to 20	3 to 5	15 cm (6 in)

Litres, gallons and widths

Litres	US gallons	About the width of a round pot	What it is
5	1.3	20 cm (8 in)	A herb pot; a small trough
10	2.6	25 cm (10 in)	The smallest useful vegetable pot
20	5	32 cm (13 in)	A "5-gallon bucket" is about 19 L
30	8	36 cm (14 in)	A pepper or a bean pot

40	10.5	40 cm (16 in)	A tomato pot; a potato bag
50	13	45 cm (18 in)	A courgette or a small tree
70	18.5	50 cm (20 in)	A fruit tree; a half-barrel is about 100 L

Weight

A 40-litre bag of potting mix weighs about 15 kg (33 lb) dry; a 40-litre pot filled, planted and watered weighs about 30 kg (65 lb), and a 70-litre tree pot about 55 kg (120 lb). Fill pots where they will stand. Anything over 5 kg (11 lb), or anything you would not lift twice, goes on a wheeled saucer or waits for help.

Appendix C - The Worksheets

Every worksheet here is free to download and print, as many times as you need, at oroenigma.com/containers.

Photocopying from the book is allowed for your own use.

C1 - The Year Plan

Our garden	Write here
Our last spring frost is usually about	
Our first autumn frost is usually about	
So, compared with the book (mid-April and mid-October), our dates shift by	
Hours of sun on the main spot in June	
Water comes from (tap, butt, hose, timer)	
The things we most want to eat	
The things we can buy cheaply and need not grow	

Container	Spring (Mar to May)	Summer (Jun to Aug)	Autumn (Sep to Nov)	Winter
Pot 1				
Pot 2				

Pot 3				
Pot 4				
Pot 5				
Pot 6				
Trough A				
Trough B				
Basket				

C2 - The Container Inventory

Number the pots (a marker pen on a plant label) and the rest of the worksheets can use the numbers.

No.	Size (L)	Material	Where, and sun hours	In it now	Notes (feet, saucer, reservoir, drip)
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					

C3 - The Going-Away List

For the neighbour, the grandchild or the paid help. Pin it to the door with the key.

For whoever is looking after the pots	Details
Away from, and back on	
The key and the gate	
Where the watering can, the hose and the tap are	
The drip timer: where it is, what time it runs, how long	
If the timer fails: water these pots every morning until it runs out of the base	
Water these every other day	
Do not water these	
Please pick and keep: beans, courgettes, cucumbers, strawberries, anything ripe	
If it is very hot: move these into the shade	
If it is going to be cold: bring these indoors	
My phone number	
A second person with a key	

Thank you. The courgettes are yours.	
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C4 - The Sowing Log

A line for every sowing. The point is the habit: a small sowing every fortnight in the growing season.

Date	What (and the variety)	Where (pot no.)	Up on	Thinned or planted out	Notes

C5 - The Watering Schedule

Week beginning: _____. Tick when watered; write "R" when the reservoir was filled; "D" when the drip line ran. In a heatwave, the small pots and the baskets need a second column of ticks.

Pot no.	Method (can, hose, drip, reservoir)	M	T	W	T	F	S	S

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C6 - The Monthly Checklist

Month: _____. Read the month in Chapter 14 first, and write this month's sowings and plantings in the blank rows.

	Done
Read the month in Chapter 14	
Sow this month:	
Plant out this month:	
Liquid feed weekly: everything flowering or fruiting	
The fortnightly salad sowing, twice	
Every empty pot refilled and resown	
Drip line and timer checked; reservoirs topped up	
Saucers emptied after rain	
Mulch topped up	
The pest walk with a torch, at dusk, once a week	
Dead leaves and finished plants removed	
Tie in, pinch out, cut back	
Order what is needed for next month	

Harvest log filled in	

C7 - The Harvest Log

What came off the patio. Fill it in through the year, and read it in January with the seed catalogue: what was worth growing, and what was not.

Date	Crop	How much	From pot no.	Notes (taste, glut, too little, next year)

C8 - The Feeding Record

Date	Pots fed	Feed used, and strength	Next due

C9 - The Problem Diary

Date	Plant and pot	What I saw	What I did	Result
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C10 - The Shopping List and Cost Tracker

Chapter 2 gives the honest costs. Write what you bought and what it cost, and compare it in December with the harvest log.

Item (pots, mix, feed, seed, plants, tools, timer)	From	Cost	Bought

Total this year			

Seed and plants to order for next year:

Crop	Variety	Sow indoors or direct	Ordered